Independent Hymn Musicianship

Realize chord symbols, transpose, introduce hymns and accompany singers.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

In this chapter

1. Read a lead sheet as a musical plan
2. Transpose by scale degree and function
3. Give a singer a reliable introduction
4. Learn a short phrase by ear
5. Accompany a person, not only a score
6. Holy, Holy, Holy in F: choose the key
7. Come Thou Fount in F: a service-ready texture
8. Come Thou Fount: accompany with confidence

1. Read a lead sheet as a musical plan

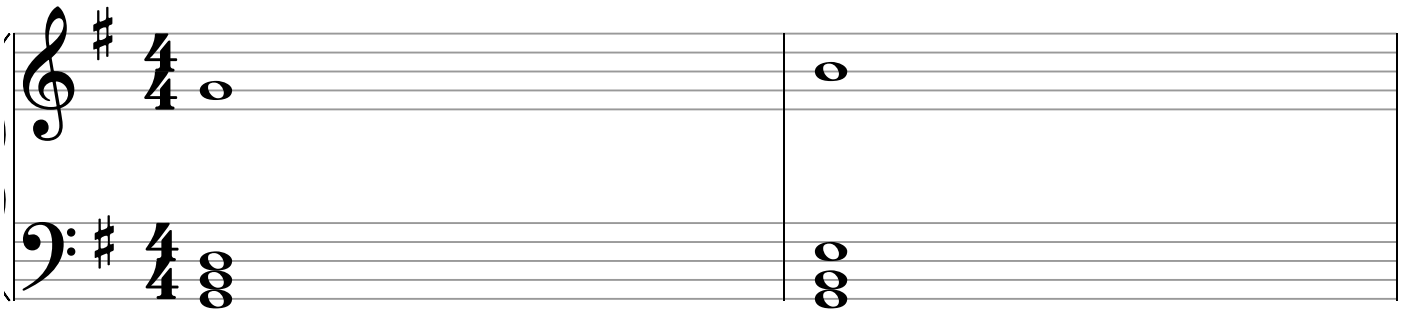
Turn chord symbols into a clear, playable accompaniment.

Read a lead sheet as a musical plan

A chord symbol names a harmony, not an exact register or pattern. In G major, use G-Em-Am-D7-G as a short model. Place the melody where it sings, choose nearby chord inversions and avoid crowding the register directly under the singer. Learn a plain bass-and-chord version before adding flowing notes. The app checks the written realization; alternative voicings belong in your independent practice.

Practise · G–Em–Am–D7–G

Name each chord and hear its function while playing the compact voicing.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Read the bass route

Play this simpler support before choosing a pattern.

Practise independently

Write the five chord symbols without notes and realize them in two textures offline. Keep the melody and chord-change locations the same.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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2. Transpose by scale degree and function
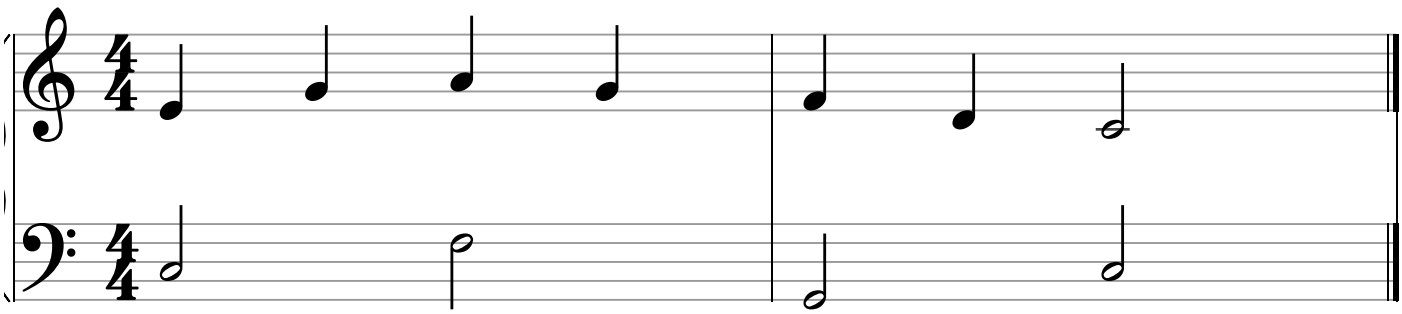
Move a phrase to a singer’s key without counting every semitone.

Transpose by scale degree and function

Label the melody with scale degrees and the chords with functions. In C, E-G-A-G is 3-5-6-5; in D it becomes F-sharp-A-B-A. I-IV-V-I becomes D-G-A-D. Check the new starting pitch and range before playing. Practise one phrase first, then the bass, then both hands. Choose a key for the singer rather than for the pianist’s favourite hand shape.

Practise · The phrase in C

Say 3-5-6-5, 4-2-1 as you play.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · The same functions in D

Prepare F-sharp and C-sharp. Keep the interval pattern.

Practise independently

Transpose the phrase into F offline, then try one hymn phrase in a second key. Name the highest and lowest melody notes before deciding the key is suitable.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

3. Give a singer a reliable introduction

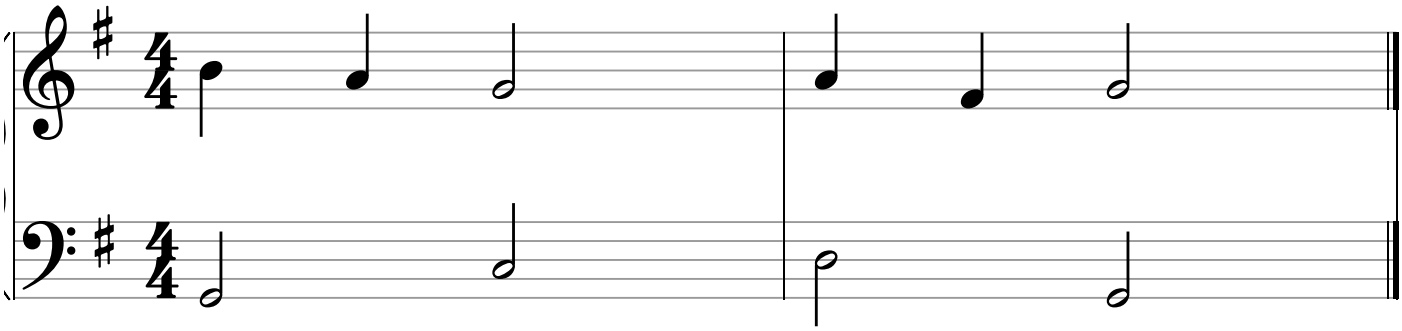
Establish key, meter, tempo and a clear entry.

Give a singer a reliable introduction

A useful introduction tells the singer when and where to enter. Use a recognizable closing phrase or a short tonic-dominant pattern, keep the intended tempo and leave room for a breath. Rehearse the pickup count explicitly. Avoid a decorative flourish that leaves the starting beat unclear. Agree on the introduction before accompanying someone.

Practise · A short introduction in G

Set the pulse, cadence on G and imagine a clear entry on the next beat.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Prepare a pickup

Count the rest, then treat D as a light pickup leading into G.

Practise independently

Choose the last two or four bars of a hymn as an introduction offline. Count an imaginary singer in, then ask a real singer whether the entry felt clear.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

4. Learn a short phrase by ear

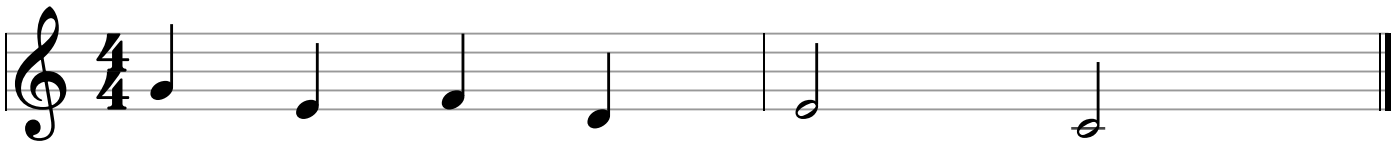
Use singing, tonal landmarks and comparison before notation.

Learn a short phrase by ear

Choose a phrase short enough to sing accurately. Find its home note and first pitch, then hear steps, repeated notes and skips. Sing before trying keys, and check only a few notes at a time. In the first exercise, use Listen, turn away from the score and sing back before playing. The app provides a reference, not an automatic assessment of a new melody you invent.

Practise · Listen, sing, then find

Listen once, look away, sing the phrase and find it at the piano. Then compare with the score.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Hear the bass function

Listen for home, away, dominant and home; name the roots before looking.

Practise independently

Choose a different familiar hymn phrase and learn it away from the screen. Write or play it from memory, then compare with a verified score to catch guessed intervals.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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5. Accompany a person, not only a score

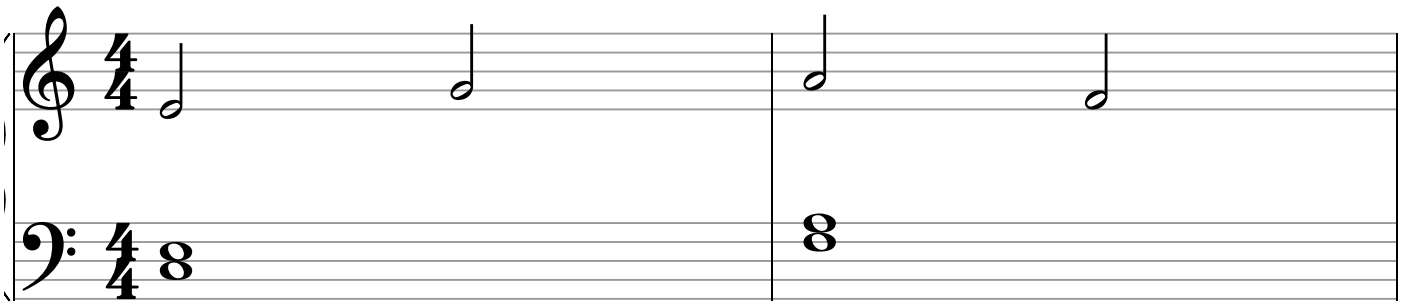
Support breaths, entries, balance and recovery.

Accompany a person, not only a score

Agree on key, tempo, introduction, verse count and ending before playing. Listen to the singer’s consonants and breaths. Keep the tune audible enough to guide an entry without overpowering the voice. If the singer skips ahead, simplify to bass and essential harmony and join at the next shared landmark. Practise with another person when possible; solo app playback cannot simulate all their timing choices.

Practise · A plain support model

Imagine singing above these quiet harmonies. Keep the pulse easy to predict.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · A secure re-entry

Start here as if joining a singer at the final phrase.

Practise independently

Rehearse with a singer or sing while playing. Agree on one held ending, one breath and one restart point. Practise a simplified recovery offline, then return to the written model for the app check.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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6. Holy, Holy, Holy in F: choose the key

Prepare the melody in F and compare its highest and lowest notes with the D-major version. Use scale degrees and functions to understand the move.

Prepare the score
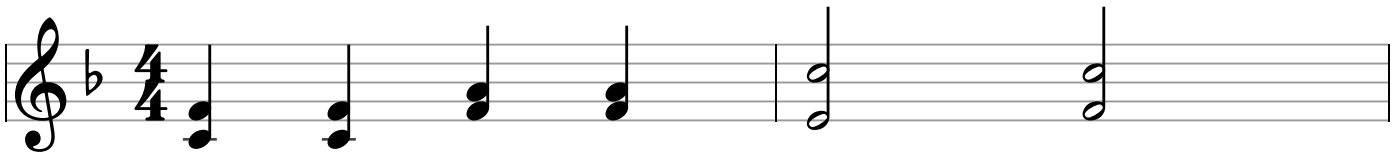
Prepare the melody in F and compare its highest and lowest notes with the D-major version. Use scale degrees and functions to understand the move.

This is a melody-led piano reduction: supporting tones change with the melody. Source inner voices may be moved by octaves or rearticulated; study their original rhythms using the source score.

Preview the key, meter, pickup and ending. Prepare a stable fingering before adding speed.

Practise · Right hand: voice the melody

Read the upper line first. Where there are two notes, keep the top voice clearer. Release unnecessary pressure.



Opening example · 4/4 · F · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand: shape the support

Count aloud and play softly. Move the arm between positions; do not hold a wide stretch.

Practise · Join the opening

Prepare the melody in F and compare its highest and lowest notes with the D-major version. Use scale degrees and functions to understand the move.

Practise · Holy, Holy, Holy in F: choose the key

Prepare the melody in F and compare its highest and lowest notes with the D-major version. Use scale degrees and functions to understand the move.

Make your own musical decision

Sing the opening in both keys. Decide which is more comfortable for your intended singer, without assuming the higher key is better.

Practise the alternative at your piano, then return to the written reference if using the app’s pitch check. Record yourself if possible and describe one audible improvement.

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7. Come Thou Fount in F: a service-ready texture

Prepare the F-major accompaniment, agree on a tempo and imagine a singer entering after a short recognizable introduction.

Prepare the score
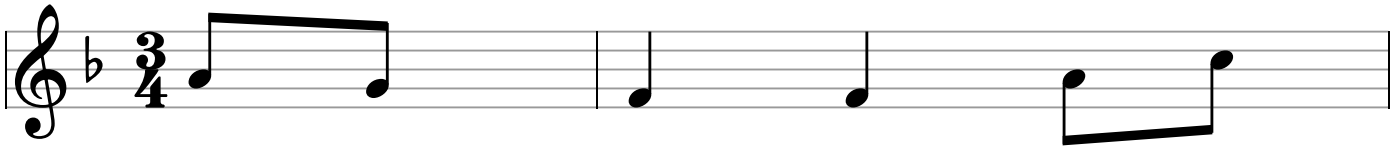
Prepare the F-major accompaniment, agree on a tempo and imagine a singer entering after a short recognizable introduction.

The left-hand pattern samples the retained source harmonies at each eighth note. It is an original piano accompaniment.

Preview the key, meter, pickup and ending. Prepare a stable fingering before adding speed.

Practise · Right hand: voice the melody

Read the upper line first. Where there are two notes, keep the top voice clearer. Release unnecessary pressure.



Opening example · 3/4 · F · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand: shape the support

Count aloud and play softly. Move the arm between positions; do not hold a wide stretch.

Practise · Join the opening

Prepare the F-major accompaniment, agree on a tempo and imagine a singer entering after a short recognizable introduction.

Practise · Come Thou Fount in F: a service-ready texture

Prepare the F-major accompaniment, agree on a tempo and imagine a singer entering after a short recognizable introduction.

Make your own musical decision

Create a two- or four-bar introduction from the ending offline. Rehearse the pickup, one breath and a shared final release with a singer if possible.

Practise the alternative at your piano, then return to the written reference if using the app’s pitch check. Record yourself if possible and describe one audible improvement.

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8. Come Thou Fount: accompany with confidence

Before the written reference run, play your own introduction offline and sing one phrase while accompanying. In the app, keep the printed D-major model clear, steady and supportive.

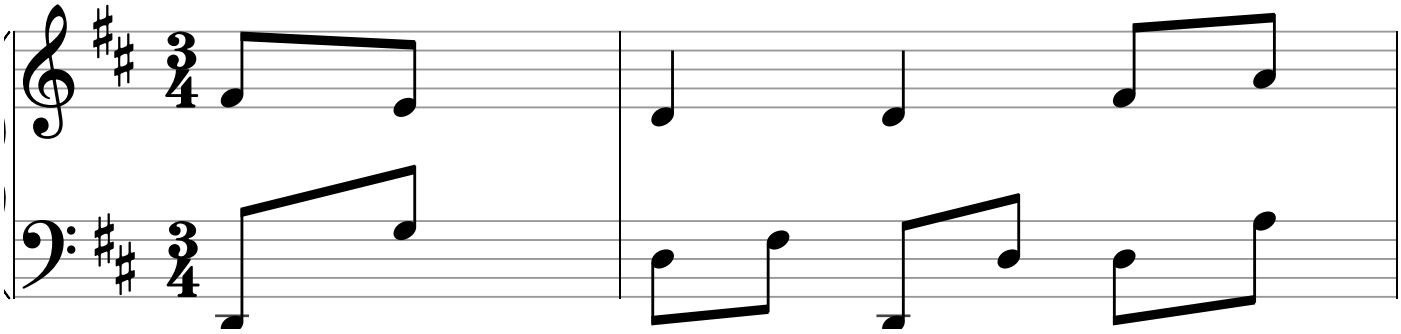
Prepare a complete performance

Before the written reference run, play your own introduction offline and sing one phrase while accompanying. In the app, keep the printed D-major model clear, steady and supportive.

Choose a tempo at which you can finish comfortably. Mark three restart points, rehearse the opening and ending, then play without stopping. Afterwards assess pulse, clarity, phrasing, balance and recovery. Completion records a reference play-through, not a graded qualification or approval of an improvised arrangement.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Come Thou Fount

Before the written reference run, play your own introduction offline and sing one phrase while accompanying. In the app, keep the printed D-major model clear, steady and supportive.



Opening example · 3/4 · D · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Your recital

Before the written reference run, play your own introduction offline and sing one phrase while accompanying. In the app, keep the printed D-major model clear, steady and supportive.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Turn chord symbols into a clear, playable accompaniment.
- ☐ Move a phrase to a singer’s key without counting every semitone.
- ☐ Establish key, meter, tempo and a clear entry.
- ☐ Use singing, tonal landmarks and comparison before notation.
- ☐ Support breaths, entries, balance and recovery.
- ☐ Before the written reference run, play your own introduction offline and sing one phrase while accompanying. In the app, keep the printed D-major model clear, steady and supportive.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
